Heidegger

Martin Heidegger is one of the most influential and enigmatic philosophers of the twentieth century. His style is unusually obscure, and the verbal manoeuvres peculiar to him help determine the shape and outcome of his inquiry. He is worth reading because so many twentieth-century movements took something from him. Existentialism, in some respects, is his godchild. He may have borrowed some of its concerns from Kierkegaard, but he reformulated them in a twentieth-century idiom that informs Sartre, Camus, Merleau-Ponty and many other French and German thinkers. Their work can be hard to approach without him.

Heidegger began with Catholic religious and theological training, including a brief period in the Jesuit novitiate. The habits of mind formed by that education can reappear much later in a transformed guise. When Heidegger makes a philosophical move, he takes it as far as it will go. His habilitation study concerned a work then attributed to Duns Scotus. Anyone who has read scholastic philosophy knows how forbidding such an undertaking is. I would hesitate even to read a dissertation on Duns Scotus, much less write one. The choice tells us something about the ambition of someone who believes he can cut a Gordian knot.

His best-known work, perhaps his greatest, is *Being and Time* (*Sein und Zeit*), published in 1927 in Husserl's phenomenological yearbook and dedicated to Edmund Husserl. Heidegger learned from Husserl, and there is a conceptual relationship between Husserl's phenomenology and the philosophy of existence Heidegger develops. Heidegger rejected the existentialist label. Historically, however, his influence on the philosophy of existence has been greater than the following gained by his own distinctive project of developing an ontology. Ontology, the inquiry into Being, was one of the foundational enterprises of Greek philosophy. Returning to Being itself, with a capital B, is an intimidating ambition, whether or not one thinks it is possible in the twentieth century.

Talking about Being is like trying to bite one's own teeth. What could we say about it? How could we come to know it? We will not find out about Being by examining individual tables, chairs or Christmas trees, or by looking for lawlike regularities in the outside world. The method is closer to introspection. This inward orientation is one strand that holds the continental tradition together. It involves a tendency to resist taking scientific inquiry as the model for all inquiry.

Heidegger knows Greek philosophy well, but thinks thought has largely gone downhill since Aristotle. Christianity, the Romans and the Enlightenment, on this view, did little to reverse the decline. The real high point was before Plato, among the pre-Socratics. Heidegger wants to recover the sophisticated naïveté of their questioning. Our understanding of ourselves and the world has diminished because we have set aside the problem of Being in favour of investigating particular beings. He wants to move from those tangible inquiries towards a more abstract and elusive question.

Think of the cave and the divided line in Plato's *Republic*. At the level of the forms, Being is rather like the light by which things become visible. It is not itself one of the visible things. We know in an ordinary way what it means to say that the grass is green,

that the lectern is made of wood or that the cup is blue. Familiarity with those uses of "is" does not tell us what Being in general is, or what holds these particular beings together. The analogy with light suggests the difference: light is unlike the objects we see in the room. This is a metaphor, but it lets us pose the question. Heidegger sets the individual objects aside to ask what it is to be and what Being discloses about itself.

Even so, he does not want a merely abstract or formal concept of Being. The starting point is everyday human experience. Instead of first constructing abstractions and making experience fit them, we start with experience and remove what is irrelevant, as if separating gold from dross. Heidegger calls the human existence he examines *Dasein*, a German term that resists translation. *Dasein* is human being in the world: finite, contingent and uncertain, marked by states such as worry, guilt and anxiety. This constellation is unlike anything else in the world. It is the setting in which Being is disclosed to us. The only perspective from which we can inquire into Being is the perspective of a being that we ourselves are.

The danger is circularity. There can be whole chapters in which Being seems to talk to itself and project itself into its own future. We remain within what I call the "intracosm", the realm of inwardness, and find it hard to break out into the "exocosm". This may be the Achilles heel of continental philosophy. Heidegger nevertheless proposes to investigate what it is to be human by being human authentically. This involves casting aside illusions and refusing to be distracted by the small events of the world. Turning inward can lead us from a pre-reflective concern with particular beings to an authentic concern with Being itself.

On my reading, the one imperative Heidegger leaves us is to be authentically. We have a responsibility to face the reality of human life, however unpleasant or trying it may be. If this opens a new level of experience and understanding, he will have contributed to our self-knowledge. The turn towards the primordial questions of the pre-Socratics recalls the Delphic injunction to Socrates and the Greeks to know themselves. The continental project similarly asks us to turn inward and find out what it means to be human.

Dasein has a threefold structure: understanding, mood and discourse. Understanding means that human existence opens a context in which things can matter. To be human is to make sense of the surrounding world and organise our experiences into a meaningful whole, a *Gestalt*. Mood includes familiar states such as happiness and sadness. It would be unusual to find an Anglo-American empiricist placing mood at the centre of philosophical development. For Heidegger it is a fact of life. Ignoring it risks turning our account of ourselves and the world into an abstraction.

The third element, discourse, means that language is constitutive of *Dasein*. What we experience becomes intelligible through what we can articulate, in the moods in which it matters to us. Everyday, unpoetic language can dull us to Being and leave us caught up in trivialities. T. S. Eliot's *Four Quartets* gives a phrase for this inauthenticity: "distracted from distraction by distraction". Heidegger calls us back to ourselves. The small beings of the world should not deprive us of Being.

Being in this sense bears an uncomfortably strong resemblance to God. Considering Heidegger's early theological formation, one might read the search for an enigmatic Being that discloses itself in peculiar ways as a twentieth-century, depersonalised form of theology. It recalls the Gospel story of the rich young man. He asks Jesus how to

become truly good. Jesus tells him to sell what he has and follow him. Heidegger seems to ask for something similar: relinquish the trivialities that occupy us and follow Being itself. The call is to authenticity. It looks, to me, like theology worn very smooth.

Being and Time appeared in 1927 under academic pressures and remained unfinished. Its underlying idea is that freedom must be earned. It is something we work towards in response to *Dasein*. We become human by confronting the facts of our existence. The first division of the published work can be read as a hermeneutics of Being. It examines the unreflective condition in which we are occupied with one particular being after another, still distracted from distraction by distraction. We deceive ourselves by attaching importance to things that do not really matter to us and ignoring what we are. In this world of contingent finitude, the least we owe ourselves is to become what we can.

The analysis of this pre-reflective condition brings out three related aspects of existence. The first is facticity, expressed in our thrownness, *Geworfenheit*. No one consulted us before we were born or became conscious. We did not ask for a world of space and time full of people, objects and problems. It is simply given. We find ourselves in a world we did not make, busying ourselves with small and often irrelevant matters.

The second aspect is existentiality. We appropriate the world for our own purposes. We take knowledge, objects, food and other things useful to us, and handle them in practical ways. Utility describes a very pragmatic aspect of our dealings with the world. The third aspect, especially visible in the pre-reflective condition, is falling or fallenness, *Verfallen*. One might also call it forfeiture. There is a radical deprivation in the human condition as Heidegger takes it up. He starts with this scarcely conscious state and tries to move us towards awareness of ourselves.

He offers no assurance that this will be pleasant, easy or readily intelligible. But how much does the business that now occupies us really matter? What profit is it to gain the whole world and lose one’s soul? I suspect this has at least one foot in Christian theology. Much of Heidegger’s account of an honest or authentic encounter with Being looks like Jesuit theology abstracted and stripped of its theological content. Strange things happen when the structure survives and the content is removed.

Fallenness is a condition of being caught in a web of *maya* or illusion. The world of particular beings, the blooming, buzzing confusion outside us, passes for what is real. Our reality, on this account, is in Being itself, rather than in the distractions we encounter simply by living. If we remain in fallenness all our lives, we forfeit our claim to be genuinely human. Becoming human requires the maturity to face life as it is instead of taking the many side roads it offers.

The vast majority of people, apparently, are caught in this inauthentic way of living. Here is the source of the twentieth-century idea of mass man. Heidegger calls it *das Man*, the anonymous “they”. We behave like members of a herd, without reflection and without facing the world on our own. Perhaps in the tradition of German Romanticism, the most Heidegger can do is press us to become individuals. Kierkegaard, one of his formative influences, wanted his gravestone to give his name and dates and, below them, “that individual”. Heidegger asks us to follow Kierkegaard in precisely that individual way: face Being for yourself. Cultivate your inward life and confront things

you would rather not think about. With effort you, too, might deserve to be called an individual.

The second division of the published work sketches what an authentic existence and a genuine encounter with *Dasein* might entail. Heidegger's wider project also calls for a philosophical history of ontology. A phenomenological "destruction" of earlier conceptions would clear the ground for a new building. He would retain the pre-Socratic legacy, much of Platonism and some of Aristotle. Beyond Aristotle the history of ontology seems to him an inauthentic dead end. Human beings have, with few exceptions, been inauthentic since they separated themselves from Being. He is also concerned with Nietzsche's challenge to the very possibility of speaking about Being.

This wish to return to an earlier, pristine state sounds to me rather like a return to the Garden of Eden. Fallenness sounds like sin and, since it is universal, rather like original sin. Heidegger explicitly denies that this is what he means. I have my doubts. Once the history of ontology has been subjected to this destruction, the world is viewed no longer *sub specie aeternitatis*, from the standpoint of eternity, but *sub specie temporis*, from the standpoint of time. This means seeing human existence from a human point of view, not from God's.

What Being discloses from this point of view is a peculiar set of conditions, many of them unpleasant. To face *Dasein* one must become accustomed to *amor fati*, or acceptance of fate, above all of one's own death. Death, anxiety, worry, care and fear are prominent in the second division. For all their harshness, we are better off facing them than dwelling on what distracts us. Conscience is also indispensable. Becoming authentic means facing death, recognising that we have a conscience and, in the language of the Gospel, being ready to sell everything in order to follow Being.

Death is a fearsome reality. A conscious person will inevitably think about it at some point, perhaps at every point. I have thought about it myself without finding much that I can say about it intelligently. Heidegger, however, proposes to think about death as the horizon of human existence. Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* popularises one aspect of this problem. In the business of everyday life we keep trying to persuade ourselves that we will go on forever and that time stretches away to an infinite horizon. This is a form of self-deception.

To think of time as a series of successive moments, time one, time two and so on without end, is to take something like the perspective of God or of the scientist. No human life experiences time that way. We live it as the horizon of our possibilities. This is why the book is called *Being and Time*: the inquiry into Being discovers that temporality is basic to our experience of it. T. S. Eliot's rose garden and his reflections on present and past time come to mind. Eliot is openly Christian, while Heidegger appears to deny or set aside the Christian connection. Yet the demand to confront our own death, a great Christian theme, is central here too.

Conscience tells us that we are caught up in trivialities and calls us back to authenticity. Heidegger's treatment can sound as though conscience says, "Sell all you have and follow me". It calls us away from particular beings and towards Being itself. Heidegger sometimes seems to assume the voice of conscience. He moves from philosopher to prophet with surprising agility. When he asks us to be ourselves and heed our conscience, he sounds to me more like Jeremiah than Sartre.

Authenticity, in this sense of confronting our own finitude, could redeem us from a pre-philosophical and scarcely human condition. With it come guilt, care and worry. Like Eliot, Heidegger seems to regard the human condition as one of radical deprivation. We are neither what we should be nor what we could be. Once we face our finitude, we find that we have obligations to ourselves that we cannot fulfil.

Heidegger calls our response *Sorge*, which can mean care, worry or concern. It has a temporal character. First, conscious human existence projects itself into the future. We experience ourselves as more than what we are here and now. In looking ahead, we encounter anxiety and dread because we come to an end and cannot evade it. We also project ourselves back into our past. Here guilt is unavoidable. It is the uncomfortable certainty that we have not been what we could have been. Heidegger is right to take this as a feature of human existence that a scientific account cannot simply rule out.

In the present we recognise a potential for freedom from absorption in particular beings that we have not fully realised. The past discloses what we could have been, the present how much freer and more authentic we might be, and the future a definite horizon. We know death is coming without knowing when. It extinguishes our possibilities without our having exhausted them. Until then there are choices to make, contexts to shape and projects to undertake. We cannot do all that we would like to do or might have done if we were eternal. We leave possibilities unrealised and owe ourselves a debt we can never repay. This is a kind of cosmic guilt.

I see here an echo of original sin divested of theology. It is part of the human condition and cannot be escaped. If we shrink reality to fit a Humean or positivist account in which guilt and the inner life can be disregarded, we turn back to particular beings and lapse into pre-philosophical inauthenticity. If we want to be human, we must have a soul, and having a soul means facing the elements of experience we cannot remove. It also means asking questions for which there may be no answers. We cannot get around the question of Being, even though it is far from clear what the question means.

It is not even clear that we would recognise the answer if it came up and shook us by the hand. The result is obscurity piled on obscurity alongside an honest confrontation with the realities of human life. This combination of difficulty and literary or psychological truthfulness is characteristic of much twentieth-century continental philosophy.

If *Dasein* demands that we live facing death instead of denying it, ethics seems to implode. The one remaining obligation is authenticity. How we undertake our projects matters more than which ones we undertake. Between now and death we cannot do everything, and we must decide which possibilities are better. The difficulty is that this emphasis on how we choose can easily shade into nihilism.

Heidegger did, after all, join the Nazi Party. His relationship to his teacher Husserl is especially troubling in this context. His first great work appeared in Husserl’s yearbook and was dedicated to him. Heidegger succeeded Husserl in the Freiburg chair in 1928, before the Nazi seizure of power. In 1933 he became rector and joined the party, while Husserl, who was Jewish, was subjected to the regime’s anti-Jewish measures. Heidegger distanced himself from his former teacher. To me, this sounds like a phenomenology of careerism. It is deeply disconcerting when a philosopher who claims a special insight into life lets us down so badly. It makes me want to read the rest of his

claims with particular care. If an unphilosophical life is more likely to make us behave decently, I might prefer to be stupid.

Historicity matters to Heidegger as much as conscience and existence. We are situated in a particular context at a particular time and oriented towards the future. Looking towards our own end brings us to what he calls thinking about the Nothing. English translations sometimes give it a capital N. In German all nouns are capitalised, so typography offers no such clue. Thinking about the Nothing is a trying exercise. It is not simply negation, but is supposed to be the source of negation. I have tried to work out what that means and run into logical difficulties. Heidegger's reply would be: so much the worse for your logic. Confront Being as it is. One can see why Carnap and the Vienna Circle found the lush ambiguity and elaborate self-indulgence so exasperating.

Heidegger produced important work during the Nazi years. It may be unfair to judge a philosopher's work by his life, depending on what one takes philosophy to be. Still, I suspect that the cultural chauvinism of the time affected him. In my reading, he gives German a privileged place as a language for philosophy, alongside Greek. One can imagine Wittgenstein turning in his grave and saying no in any language. Philosophy can be done in any language. Heidegger's almost mystical or magical conception of language becomes especially apparent in the later work, making an already difficult philosophy harder still.

In his *Introduction to Metaphysics*, Heidegger takes up Nietzsche's objection that our ideas about Being have evaporated into mist. Nietzsche is like a seismograph that registers the failings of the Western tradition and shows where they lead: we no longer know how to speak of Being. Heidegger treats that diagnosis as evidence of the inauthenticity of the history of philosophy since the Greeks. He seeks a way beyond the Nietzschean impasse by going back to the pre-Socratics, whose work Nietzsche also admired.

After the war, Heidegger continued to write difficult, almost impenetrable prose and devoted much attention to the pre-Socratics. The title of his collection *Holzwege* literally evokes paths in the woods. You go walking and find tracks that lead nowhere, trails that end in an impasse. The essays are their logical or psychological equivalents. "Blind alleys" would capture something of the title. The collection includes an elaborate essay on Anaximander, one of the Ionian investigators of nature. Heidegger manages to draw dozens of pages from a single surviving fragment. The interpretation is remarkably detailed and, to my mind, implausible and self-referential.

The later work is even more difficult than the earlier work, but it extends the earlier concern with Being and with its sources in pre-Socratic thought. By the end of Heidegger's life the great philosophical exemplar is no longer Plato's *Dialogues*, but the poem of Parmenides. Parmenides enjoins us to think and say that Being is and bars us from the other way. For Heidegger, this means that ontology is the first and fundamental concern of human beings, on which the rest depends. The forbidding and abstract Parmenides exemplifies the pre-Socratic innocence to which Heidegger wants to return.

There are serious difficulties with the project. Heidegger's impenetrability often comes close to self-parody. When he writes about the Nothing and says, in effect, that the Nothing "noths" rather than negates, I do not know what this Nothing is. I learn much

about what his ideas are not, but I cannot see what sensible predicate one could attach to the Nothing. What can we think or say about it? Heidegger seems to think we can say a great deal, but I am not sure what it amounts to.

His writings often proceed by elaborate wordplay. Consider *unheimlich*, "uncanny". Heidegger uses it to describe our feeling when we encounter *Dasein* and no longer know our way around the world. *Heim* means home. To be *unheimlich* in this sense is to be unhomely, not to feel at home in the world. Heidegger brings together uncanniness, uncertainty, anxiety and a kind of homesickness for our connection to Being. The overlap can be messy, but it is also a source of richness. He often seems to care more about connotation than denotation. His elaborate etymologies in both Greek and German can be implausible. When he does not know the historical origin of a word, it can seem as though he invents one and then offers a philosophical argument for why he alone, against the lexicographers, has uncovered it.

The broader problem concerns morality, mysticism and nihilism. When we leave public discourse about particular beings and turn to inwardness, it becomes very hard to put what is happening into intelligible words. We risk talking to ourselves, which is the opposite of the philosophical enterprise. Nihilism is another possibility. One might almost define it as speech indistinguishable from silence. The discussion of the Nothing can strike me as a sophisticated way of saying nothing. Heidegger attempts the linguistically impossible too much of the time.

My final difficulty is that this collection of insights, tautologies, obscure expressions and neologisms looks like a transformation of theology. The ontological search is theology with God left out. We worship ourselves and owe duties to ourselves instead of to a deity. The one duty is to be ourselves. This approaches self-worship as well as solipsism. What else is there to worship if there is only me? Solipsism is a recurrent danger in systems that start from the inside and work outwards. Many never find their way out.

Heidegger had relatively little influence in the Anglo-American philosophical world as described here. Carnap's scathing treatment takes him as an example of what happens when metaphysics outruns intelligible speech. It is easy to see why a scientifically minded philosopher might prefer tables, chairs, atoms and physics to accounts of dread and death. Heidegger did, however, have influence in theology. Paul Tillich, the systematic theologian, made his debt to Heidegger explicit. Rudolf Bultmann's demythologising of Christianity likewise draws on Heidegger. In these cases, an old theological problem becomes Heideggerian philosophy, which in turn becomes a new theological problem. Perhaps the enigmatic Being at the centre of Heidegger's thought can be understood as the silence of God.